Narrative tenses

Objective: To narrate a story or a news event in the past by combining the past simple, past continuous and past perfect in a clear order.

The idea in two lines: Narrative tenses work together: the **past simple** carries the main events, the **past continuous** sets the background, and the **past perfect** goes back to an earlier action.

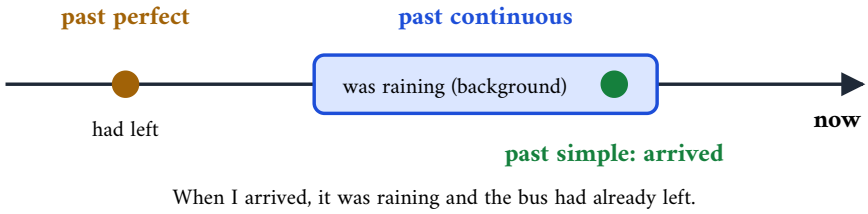


Figure 1: The past perfect is earlier than the main event (past simple), which happens during a background action (past continuous).

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Past simple:** the main, completed events of the story, in the order they happened.
2. **Past continuous** (was / were + -ing): background, description, or an action interrupted by another.
3. **Past perfect** (had + past participle): an action that happened **before** another past action.
4. **Time connectors:** when, while, as, as soon as, after, before, by the time, then, suddenly, eventually.
5. **After / before** already show the order, so the past perfect is sometimes optional with them.
6. **Story structure:** setting (background) → events → climax → ending.

🟢 Examples

1. Put the verbs in the right tense: "When the police (arrive), the thief (already / escape)." **Answer:** When the police *arrived*, the thief *had already escaped*. **Explanation:** the escape happened first.
2. "The sun (shine) and the children (play) when the storm (start)." **Answer:** The sun *was shining* and the children *were playing* when the storm *started*.
3. Join with *by the time*: "The firemen came. The house burned down before that." **Answer:** *By the time* the firemen came, the house *had burned* down.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Using the past simple for the earlier action when the order is unclear.
- Wrong form of the past perfect: *had went* ✕ → **had gone** ✓.
- Writing the whole story in the past continuous.
- Switching to the present in the middle of the narrative.

🟡 Quick review

- Main events ⇒ past simple.
- Background ⇒ past continuous.
- Earlier action ⇒ had + past participle.
- Connectors make the order clear.
- Stay in the past from start to end.

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